

Microsoft's Xamarin goes the open source way

A couple of months after acquiring it, Microsoft has pushed cross-platform app development tool vendor Xamarin to choose the fast-growing open source path. The new development was announced during Xamarin's Evolve developer conference that was held in Orlando recently.

Although Microsoft had suggested the community integration at its Build 2016 conference last month, Xamarin co-founder Miguel de Icaza formally announced its open source SDKs to get started on the new front, during the Evolve conference. These new Xamarin SDKs will be available for Android, iOS and Mac OS under the MIT licence. Additionally, the San Francisco, California-based company is set to contribute its development kits to the .NET Foundation.

"The Xamarin engineering team will now be working in our repositories on GitHub, continuing to make the Xamarin SDKs better," Icaza wrote in a blog post. "The future of native cross-platform mobile development is now in the hands of every developer, and we're excited to see where you'll take the platform," he added.

The Xamarin SDKs will include Mono runtime ports for iOS and Android, basic command-line build tools and the Xamarin.Forms UI framework. However, the Xamarin IDE for Mac OS will still be available as a closed-source offering.

To make developers aware of the new developments, Xamarin has enhanced its Web presence. There is a new website that has source codes to let a developer easily build native mobile apps and UIs for Android and iOS devices. In addition to choosing the open source route, Microsoft has upgraded the experience for Xamarin's community by bringing its Visual Studio to Mac. This will help developers build native iOS apps directly using C#.

CareKit is an extension to last year's ResearchKit. The open source software framework is designed to empower individuals with healthcare solutions via their iPhone or iPad.

"We believe that giving individuals the tools to understand what is happening with their health is incredibly powerful, and apps designed using CareKit make this a reality by empowering people to take a more active role in their care," Apple's chief operating officer Jeff Williams had said in a statement at the time of announcing CareKit back in March.



If you want to use CareKit for your next project, you can access its code directly from GitHub. Apple provides you a CareKit BSD licence to formally support your developments.

CareKit comes in four different modules in the initial stage. There is the 'Care Card' to let you track individual care plans and action items using the built-in sensors of the Apple Watch or iPhone. You can use the provided 'Symptom and Measurement Tracker' to

record symptoms and progress using surveys, photos, or activities through an accelerometer or gyroscope on the iOS device. Besides, there is the 'Insight Dashboard' and 'Connect' modules to make it easy for users to know their health performance in real-time.

In addition to the community-driven healthcare efforts, Apple has launched its CareKit blog. This is a one-stop online place where individuals, physicians and engineers can share their experiences and gain some new knowledge to make their lives healthy and safe.

"The CareKit blog will provide individuals, physicians and engineers all over the world with a simple way to share experiences and best practices on how to take advantage of the CareKit framework. It's also a great place to check for stories of apps implementing CareKit in innovative ways," the CareKit team has written in a blog post.

Apple's release of the open source CareKit is likely to increase competition in the existing mobile health market. It initially will not be a choice for developers in emerging markets such as India and China. However, the Cupertino giant is apparently set to make it a successful offering for developed regions like the US and Europe.

Black Lab Linux 7.6 released with XFCE 4.12 desktop enhancements

Black Lab Linux has announced the launch of its Black Lab Linux 7.6 as the latest Ubuntu based custom Linux distribution. The new version is powered by Linux Kernel 2.19.0-58, and comes bundled with XFCE 4.12 desktop enhancements to deliver a fresh user experience.

Unlike its previous versions, Black Lab Linux 7.6 has preloaded apps such as LibreOffice 5.1.2, Thunderbird 38.6.0 and a Spotify client. The new distro additionally comes with Mozilla Firefox 45.0.2 pre-installed as well as providing access to Gmusicbrowser, the HexChat IRC client, and a Skippy XD